

Payroll

UI/UX Product Standard

Domain Standard #07 · Modern Payroll Operations

Design direction: Modern Payroll OS · Trust-first · Transparent · Rule-aware · Employee-centered

Purpose: Establish a reusable UI/UX standard for payroll processing, salary structures, attendance inputs, deductions, taxes, payslips, approvals, compliance and employee self-service.

Modernity rule: Payroll should feel like a current employee-finance experience, while preserving calculation transparency, privacy, control and auditability.

1. Payroll Product Definition

Payroll products convert workforce and compensation inputs into accurate, compliant and explainable pay outcomes. The UX must make complex rules understandable without exposing users to unnecessary calculation complexity.

Core UX objective: help payroll teams process pay accurately and help employees understand their compensation clearly.

Primary user groups

- **Payroll administrators:** payroll runs, corrections, approvals, deductions and reporting.
- **HR teams:** employee changes, compensation inputs, attendance and policy configuration.
- **Managers:** approvals, variable pay and team-level exceptions.
- **Employees:** payslips, earnings, deductions, tax information and payroll queries.
- **Finance/compliance users:** payroll accounting, statutory reporting and audit evidence.

2. Modern Payroll Design Language

Style type: Modern Payroll OS / Trust-first Employee Finance

- **Visual tone:** calm, transparent, secure and approachable.
- **Layout:** structured workspaces with strong separation between inputs, calculations, exceptions and final outputs.
- **Density:** medium-to-high for administrators; simplified for employee self-service.
- **Typography:** highly legible with strong hierarchy for salary totals and pay-period context.
- **Color:** neutral foundation with restrained brand accent and semantic status colors.
- **Interaction:** guided processing, bulk actions, contextual review and progressive disclosure.
- **Privacy:** sensitive salary and tax information must be intentionally exposed by role and context.
- **Safety:** payroll submission, reversal and correction actions require clear states and confirmation.

3. Current Payroll UI Pattern Expectations

Use modern SaaS and employee-finance patterns while keeping payroll calculations explainable and controlled.

Pattern	Payroll expectation	Example
Payroll command center	Show current pay run state, progress, exceptions and deadlines.	March payroll: 82% processed, 6 exceptions.
Pay-period context	Keep payroll month/period visible throughout processing.	September 2026 · Monthly · India entity.
Exception-first workflow	Prioritize records requiring intervention.	Missing bank details, negative net pay, failed validation.
Calculation drill-down	Let users inspect how totals were produced.	Gross → earnings → deductions → taxes → net.
Employee pay snapshot	Give employees a concise view of earnings and deductions.	Net pay, gross pay, deductions, pay date.
Split review workspace	Compare current and previous payroll or employee changes.	Current salary vs previous month.
Bulk processing	Support high-volume payroll operations with safeguards.	Approve 250 validated employee records.
Audit timeline	Show important payroll changes and approvals.	Edited → validated → approved → processed.

Pattern	Payroll expectation	Example
Guided correction	Make corrections explicit rather than silently changing results.	Correct variable pay → recalculate → review.
AI assistance	Support anomaly detection and explanation without autonomous posting.	Flag unusual deduction and request review.

4. Payroll Information Architecture

- **Payroll Home:** active pay runs, deadlines, exceptions and key payroll metrics.
- **Payroll Runs:** draft, validation, review, approval, processing and completion.
- **Employees:** compensation, payroll profile, bank details and tax information.
- **Earnings:** salary, allowances, bonuses, commissions and variable pay.
- **Deductions:** taxes, benefits, loans, advances and other deductions.
- **Attendance & Inputs:** attendance, overtime, leave and payroll-impacting changes.
- **Approvals:** manager, HR, finance and payroll approvals.
- **Payslips:** employee payslips, statements and historical records.
- **Reports & Compliance:** payroll summaries, statutory outputs and audit reports.
- **Configuration:** pay schedules, salary components, rules, permissions and integrations.

5. Payroll Navigation Standard

Recommended model: Payroll Workspace → Pay Period → Employee/Run → Validation → Review → Approval → Processing → Audit.

- Keep the active payroll period visible.
- Make processing status persistent across screens.
- Expose only role-relevant payroll actions.
- Preserve context when moving from exceptions to employee records.
- Use global search for employees, payroll runs and transaction identifiers.
- Provide saved views for recurring operational tasks.

6. Payroll Design System Foundations

Foundation	Payroll standard
Grid	12-column desktop workspace with optimized table/detail layouts.
Spacing	4px base; 8/12/16/24/32px rhythm.
Typography	Modern sans-serif; emphasize pay-period and monetary hierarchy.
Numbers	Consistent currency, decimals, percentages and negative-value conventions.
Status	Use explicit labels alongside semantic color.
Tables	Dense but readable; support sorting, filtering, pinned columns and export.
Privacy	Mask or minimize sensitive values when full visibility is unnecessary.
Motion	Subtle progress and state transitions; avoid decorative animation.

7. Payroll Status Model

- **Draft:** inputs are being prepared.
- **Validating:** system checks are running.
- **Exception:** one or more records require intervention.
- **Ready for Review:** validation has completed.
- **Approved:** authorized for processing.
- **Processing:** payroll is being finalized.
- **Processed:** payroll outcome is complete.
- **Paid:** payment has been confirmed where integrated.
- **Reversed/Corrected:** prior result has been explicitly adjusted.

8. Payroll Command Center

- Show active pay period, pay date and processing deadline.
- Use progress indicators for payroll completion.
- Surface exceptions before completed records.
- Show employee count, gross payroll, deductions and net payroll where authorized.
- Provide direct entry points to validation errors and approval queues.
- Support drill-down from payroll summary to employee-level calculation.

9. Payroll Run UX

- Use a guided multi-stage process: Inputs → Validate → Review → Approve → Process.
- Show completion criteria for each stage.
- Separate warnings from blocking errors.
- Provide affected employee counts for validation issues.
- Allow safe bulk correction where appropriate.
- Do not hide calculation changes after recalculation.
- Maintain a visible audit history of material payroll actions.

10. Salary & Compensation UX

- Separate fixed salary, variable earnings, allowances and deductions.
- Show effective dates for compensation changes.
- Clearly distinguish current, previous and proposed compensation.
- Use side-by-side comparisons for salary revisions.
- Explain downstream payroll impact before final approval.
- Restrict sensitive compensation data according to role.

11. Payslip UX

- Make pay period, pay date, gross pay and net pay immediately visible.

- Group earnings and deductions separately.
- Show totals with clear calculation hierarchy.
- Provide contextual explanations for unfamiliar payroll components.
- Allow secure download/share mechanisms where supported.
- Provide historical payslip access with search/filter by period.
- Use employee-friendly terminology while retaining official component names where required.

12. Employee Self-Service Payroll

- Prioritize payslip, tax information, bank/payment details and payroll-related requests.
- Use a simplified employee experience distinct from payroll-admin screens.
- Show upcoming pay date and latest payroll status when available.
- Provide clear explanations for changes in take-home pay.
- Use contextual help for payroll terminology.
- Provide a secure route for payroll questions or corrections.

13. Validation & Exception UX

Payroll errors can directly affect employee pay, so validation must be explicit, actionable and traceable.

- Classify issues as blocking errors, warnings and informational notices.
- Explain what is wrong, who/what is affected and how to resolve it.
- Link the issue directly to the relevant employee or input.
- Support bulk resolution for repeated safe issues.
- After correction, show the validation result again.
- Preserve the original and corrected state in the audit trail.

14. Approval & Control UX

- Display payroll period, employee count, total payroll and unresolved exceptions before approval.
- Show approval authority and current approver.
- Require explicit confirmation for final payroll processing.
- Record approver identity and timestamp.
- Prevent unauthorized users from bypassing required approval steps.
- Provide controlled reversal/correction paths rather than ambiguous destructive actions.

15. Payroll Reporting & Analytics

- Provide payroll cost trends, headcount cost, earnings/deductions and variance views.
- Always label period, entity and comparison baseline.
- Support drill-down from summary to employee or component where authorized.
- Distinguish actual processed payroll from forecast or estimated payroll.
- Provide export options with clear data scope.

- Use charts to answer financial/workforce questions rather than decorate the dashboard.

16. AI & Intelligent Payroll Standard

AI should reduce administrative effort without becoming an opaque source of payroll truth.

- Use AI for anomaly detection, payroll summaries, classification suggestions and natural-language explanations.
- Clearly label AI-generated recommendations.
- Show evidence or contributing fields for anomaly flags where possible.
- Require human review for consequential changes unless a formally authorized automation exists.
- Never silently modify salary, tax or payroll records.
- Keep feedback and correction mechanisms available.

17. Example — Monthly Payroll Flow

- **1. Select period:** choose pay period and confirm organizational scope.
- **2. Gather inputs:** attendance, leave, compensation and variable pay.
- **3. Validate:** identify missing or inconsistent records.
- **4. Resolve exceptions:** correct issues with traceability.
- **5. Review:** inspect payroll totals and employee-level changes.
- **6. Approve:** authorized users approve the payroll run.
- **7. Process:** finalize payroll and create downstream outputs.
- **8. Audit:** preserve final result, approvals and processing history.

18. Example — Employee Pay Change

- Display current compensation and proposed change side by side.
- Show effective date and reason.
- Preview payroll impact.
- Identify required approvals.
- Confirm and save the change.
- Record the change in employee/payroll history.

19. Accessibility, Privacy & Security UX

- Target WCAG 2.2 AA for core workflows.
- Never rely on color alone for payroll status or validation.
- Support keyboard navigation and visible focus states.
- Minimize sensitive payroll data exposure by default.
- Use clear session, access and permission feedback.
- Provide accessible alternatives for charts and visual payroll summaries.
- Do not expose full salary/tax information in notifications or insecure contexts.

20. Responsive Strategy

- **Desktop:** primary environment for payroll processing, validation, reporting and administration.
- **Tablet:** approvals, review and operational monitoring.
- **Mobile:** employee payslips, payroll notifications, requests and approvals.
- Transform tables into prioritized employee/payroll cards on smaller screens.
- Protect sensitive payroll information on shared or mobile devices.

21. Payroll UX Quality Gates

Gate	Validation question
Calculation clarity	Can users understand how the pay outcome was produced?

Gate	Validation question
Accuracy	Does the workflow minimize payroll-entry and interpretation errors?
Privacy	Is sensitive compensation information exposed only when necessary?
Exception handling	Can payroll teams quickly identify and resolve blockers?
Control	Are approval, permission and processing boundaries explicit?
Traceability	Can every material change be explained through history/audit?
Employee clarity	Can employees understand their payslip without payroll expertise?
Modernity	Does the experience use current SaaS patterns without compromising trust?

22. Design-Glanza Product Builder Rules

- Generate a payroll-specific design system before generating screens.
- Treat Employee, Pay Period, Payroll Run, Salary Component, Earning, Deduction, Tax, Payslip, Approval and Payroll Exception as reusable domain objects.
- Generate realistic states including Draft, Validating, Exception, Ready for Review, Approved, Processing, Processed, Paid and Corrected.
- Use modern patterns: command center, period-aware navigation, exception queues, split comparison views, drill-down calculations, contextual drawers and saved views.
- Make monetary values, effective dates and payroll status consistently formatted.
- Build privacy-aware role permissions into the UI architecture.
- Keep AI suggestions visibly distinct from authoritative payroll data.
- Audit calculations, permissions, accessibility, correction flows and audit history before final delivery.

23. Payroll Standard Summary

Style: Modern Payroll OS / Trust-first Employee Finance

UX model: Prepare → Validate → Resolve → Review → Approve → Process → Explain → Audit

Visual priority: pay-period context → payroll state → exceptions → calculation → action → evidence

Modern patterns: command center, exception-first queues, calculation drill-down, split comparison, employee pay snapshot and responsible AI

Non-negotiables: accuracy, privacy, transparency, auditability, controlled processing, accessibility and employee clarity.

Domain Standard #07 for the Design-Glanza domain library. Jurisdiction-specific payroll laws, tax rules, statutory requirements and organization policies should extend this baseline rather than being assumed universally.